Direct Realism

A workbook to use alongside the Direct Realism slideshow. Work through it slide by slide, or use it on its own to revise.

This workbook follows the slideshow in order. Each part matches a group of slides. Read the short summary, then complete the tasks. If you miss a lesson, you can still work through it on your own: everything you need is in the boxes.

In this workbook

1. The questions in the philosophy of perception (slides 1–2)
2. What is direct realism? (slides 3–4)
3. Problem 1: perceptual variation (slides 5–7)
4. Problem 2: the argument from illusion (slides 8–9)
5. Problem 3: the argument from hallucination (slides 10–11)
6. Problem 4: the time-lag argument (slide 12)
7. Exam practice: 5-mark questions (slides 13–14)
8. Revision summary and quick-check quiz

Part 01 The questions in perception

The philosophy of perception is the area of epistemology that asks how our senses relate us to the world. There are two broad options.

1. Our senses relate us to the world directly and immediately.
2. Our senses relate us to the world indirectly, through some process or information in the mind or brain.

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Perception	Becoming aware of things through the senses (sight, hearing, touch, taste, smell).
Epistemology	The branch of philosophy that studies knowledge and how we gain it.

Mind-independent	Existing whether or not anyone perceives or thinks about it.
Immediately	Without anything 'in between' the perceiver and the object.
Relational property	A property an object has only in relation to something else, e.g. 'to my left', 'two metres away'.

Task In your own words, write down the big question that the philosophy of perception is trying to answer.

Part 02 What is direct realism?

Direct realism, sometimes called naïve realism, is the common-sense theory of perception. It makes two key claims.

Key Thesis

1. Directly: we perceive physical objects immediately, as they are. There is nothing in between me and the table.
2. Realism: what we perceive is real. It exists independently of the mind, and it keeps existing when nobody perceives it.

Key idea When I look at a table, I see the table itself, not a picture or representation of it in my mind.

Task Fill in the gaps.

Direct realism is sometimes called _____ realism. It claims we perceive objects _____, which means with nothing in between. It also claims that what we perceive is _____ – it exists _____ of the mind.

Task Look at the tables and chairs on slide 4. Using that picture, explain both claims of direct realism in two sentences.

Part 03 Problem 1: perceptual variation

Slide 5 lists four problems for direct realism. The first is perceptual variation.

When you walk around a chair, your experience of it changes: its shape and size look different from each angle. But the chair itself does not change. If my experience changes while the chair stays the same, then what I experience and the chair cannot be the same thing. So, the argument concludes, I do not perceive the chair directly.

The argument in standard form

1. The properties I perceive in an object change as my position or conditions change.
2. The properties of the physical object itself do not change.
3. So what I immediately perceive is not identical to the physical object.
4. Therefore we do not perceive physical objects directly. Direct realism is false.

Direct realist response

The direct realist says we perceive relational properties as well as the object. How big or what shape a chair looks depends on its relation to me – for example, its distance and angle. These are real features of the situation, not something in my mind. So the chair looking different from different places is exactly what we would expect if we see it directly.

> Task Which premise does the direct realist reject? Explain why in two or three sentences.

Part 04 Problem 2: the argument from illusion

Put a straight pencil in a glass of water and it looks bent. We know the pencil is straight, yet it appears crooked. So what I am aware of (a bent appearance) and the object in the world (a straight pencil) are

different things. The argument concludes that I see something in my mind that represents the pencil, not the pencil itself.

The argument in standard form

1. In an illusion, an object appears to have a property it does not have (the pencil looks bent).
2. What I perceive does have that property (I am aware of something bent).
3. So what I perceive is not the physical object.
4. Therefore we do not perceive physical objects directly.

Direct realist response

Again, the direct realist points to relational properties. The pencil is in a particular relationship with light and water, and light refracts as it passes between them. Seeing the pencil as bent is seeing the real pencil in those real conditions. We do not need a bent 'mental object' to explain it – this response rejects premise 2.

Task Give your own example of an illusion. Then explain how a direct realist would deal with it.

Part 05 Problem 3: hallucination

In a hallucination we have an experience of something that does not exist at all. A well-known literary example is Macbeth's vision of a dagger in Shakespeare's play (Act 2, Scene 1). Note: slide 10 names Hamlet; the dagger scene is from Macbeth.

A hallucination can be subjectively indistinguishable from a real perception – from the inside, you cannot tell them apart. If they feel the same, perhaps they have the same kind of object: something in the mind. And if that is what we are aware of in hallucination, perhaps it is what we are aware of in ordinary perception too.

The argument in standard form

1. In a hallucination I am aware of something, but not a physical object.
2. A hallucination can be subjectively indistinguishable from a real perception.
3. If two experiences are indistinguishable, they have the same kind of immediate object.
4. Therefore in real perception, too, I am immediately aware of something mental, not a physical object.

Direct realist response: disjunctivism

The disjunctive theory says that perceiving and hallucinating are two completely different kinds of mental state, even if they feel the same. Either I am perceiving a real object, or I am hallucinating. Hallucination tells us nothing about what normal perception is like. This response rejects premise 3.

Key idea 'Disjunctive' comes from 'disjunction' – an either/or statement. Either a genuine perception or a hallucination.

Task Explain why the disjunctive theory is called 'disjunctive', and which premise it attacks.

Part 06 Problem 4: the time-lag argument

The time-lag argument comes from physics. Light takes time to travel. Light from the Sun takes about eight minutes to reach us, and light from distant stars can take thousands or even millions of years. So when I look at the Sun, I see it as it was, not as it is now. A star I see may no longer exist. If what I see is in the past, I cannot be seeing the object directly as it is now.

The argument in standard form

1. Light takes time to travel from an object to my eyes.
2. So what I see shows the object as it was, not as it is now.
3. Anything I perceive directly must exist at the moment I perceive it.
4. Therefore I do not perceive physical objects directly.

Direct realist response

The slideshow does not give a response to this one, so think about it yourself. One standard reply is that the direct realist can accept we see objects as they were. Seeing the past is still seeing the real object itself, not a mental image – the delay is just part of how perception works. This rejects premise 3.

Task Do you find the time-lag argument convincing? Give one reason for and one reason against.

Summary: the four problems

Problem	Example	Direct realist response
Perceptual variation		
Illusion		
Hallucination		
Time lag		

Part 07 Exam practice: 5-mark questions

A 5-mark question tests AO1 only: knowledge and understanding. You do not need to evaluate. Aim for a precise, well-ordered explanation of about 150–200 words.

Model structure for a 5-mark answer

1. Define the key idea precisely in one sentence.
2. Set out the argument step by step (the premises and conclusion).
3. Use one clear example to show what you mean.
4. Finish by stating the conclusion and what it shows.

Model answer: Explain direct realism (5)

Read the model answer on slide 13. Highlight: (a) the definition, (b) the first claim, (c) the second claim, (d) each example.

Task Now write your own answer: Explain the argument from perceptual variation against direct realism. (5 marks)

Task Explain the argument from illusion against direct realism. (5 marks)

Task Explain the argument from hallucination against direct realism. (5 marks)

Task Explain the time-lag argument against direct realism. (5 marks)

Part 08 Revision summary and quiz

Revision summary

1. Direct realism: we perceive mind-independent physical objects directly (immediately), as they are.

2. Perceptual variation: experience changes while the object does not. Response: we perceive relational properties.
3. Illusion: the straight pencil looks bent. Response: relational properties of light and water.
4. Hallucination: subjectively indistinguishable from perception. Response: disjunctivism.
5. Time lag: we see objects as they were. Response: seeing the past is still seeing the object.

Quick-check quiz

1. What is another name for direct realism?
2. What are the two key claims of direct realism?
3. What is a relational property? Give an example.
4. What is the example used for the argument from illusion?
5. What does 'subjectively indistinguishable' mean?
6. What does the disjunctive theory claim?
7. Roughly how long does light from the Sun take to reach us?
8. Which problem for direct realism comes from physics?

Answers (fold back or cover)

1. Naïve realism.
2. We perceive objects directly/immediately; the objects are real and mind-independent.
3. A property something has in relation to something else, e.g. being two metres from me.
4. A straight pencil looking bent in a glass of water.
5. From the inside, you cannot tell the two experiences apart.
6. Perceiving and hallucinating are different kinds of mental state, even if they feel the same.
7. About eight minutes.
8. The time-lag argument.